

ABES Engineering College, Ghaziabad

VALUE EDUCATION CELL

Notes:Unit-1



EXISTENCE IS CO-EXISTENCE

**Universal Human Values and Professional Ethics (UHVPE)
(RVE- 301)**

CHAPTER ONE

Understanding Value Education

1.1 Need for Value Education

- All human beings continuously aspire for a happy life, a fulfilling and successful life, and the purpose of education is to provide adequate competence to actualize this aspiration.
- For this, first of all it is essential to understand- what is really VALUABLE for human being, and, what is really conducive to a happy and fulfilling life? - this is the VALUE domain. Then, it is essential to know- How to actualize it? How to make it happen? – this is the domain of ‘SKILLS’. Hence there is an essential complementarity between ‘VALUES’ and ‘SKILLS’ for the success of any human endeavor.
- The subject which enables us to understand ‘What is Valuable’ for human happiness is called Value Education’ (VE)
- Thus, VE enables us to understand our needs and visualize our goals correctly and also indicate the direction for their fulfillment. It also helps to remove our confusions and contradictions and bring harmony at all levels.
- The present education system has become largely skill-based. The prime emphasis is on science and technology. However, science and technology can only help to provide the means to achieve what is considered valuable. It is NOT within the scope of science and technology to provide the competence of deciding what really is valuable.
- VE is a crucial missing link in the present education system. Because of this deficiency, most of our efforts may prove to be counterproductive and serious crises at the individual, societal and environmental level are manifesting. Hence there is a strong need to rectify this situation!

1.2 Basic Guidelines for Value Education

In order for any course to qualify for Value Education, the following guidelines for the content of the course are important:

- ❑ **Universal:** It needs to be applicable to all human beings irrespective of cast, creed, nationalities, religion, etc. for all times and space.
- ❑ **Rational:** It has to appeal to human reasoning.
- ❑ **Natural and verifiable:** It has to be naturally acceptable to the human being who goes through the course and there needs to be every provision in nature for its fulfillment. It needs to be verifiable and experientially verifiable, and not based on dogmas, beliefs or assumptions.
- ❑ **All encompassing:** It needs to be cover all dimensions (realization, thought, behavior and work) & levels (individual, family, society, nature & existence) of human life and profession.
- ❑ **Leading to harmony:** The Value Education ultimately is targeted to promote harmony within the individual, harmony among human beings and harmony with nature.

1.3 Content of Value Education

What are Human Values?

Value of any unit in this existence is its participation in the larger order of which it is a part. eg. Value of a pen is that it can write. Here writing is the participation of the pen in the bigger order in which pen, paper, human being, all are present. Value of an eye is that it can be used for seeing. Value of a spinach plant is that it gives nutrition to animals and humans. What is the value of a human being? This question implies what is the participation of a human being in the bigger order? That bigger order includes human beings, plants, air, water, soil, animals, birds etc. The value of a human being is the participation of human being to ensure the continuity of harmony in that order. In order to understand human values, we need to study human being along with all that is there in the existence, and the role of human being in the relationship with each and every unit in the existence.

Scope of study

As mentioned above, any course on value education must include:

- All dimensions- thought, behavior, work & realization, and
- All levels- individual, family, society, nature & existence of human living.

Accordingly, the content of Value Education will be to understand myself, my aspirations, my happiness and understand the other entities in existence vis-à-vis the human being, understand the goal of human life comprehensively, understand the innate interconnectedness, order, the co-existence, the self-regulation and the cycle in the nature. It should encompass harmony at various levels, namely, individual, family, society, nature and existence. And finally it is to learn to live in accordance with this understanding by being vigilant to one's thought, behavior and work.

1.4 Process of Value Education

The process of value education has to be ascertained before we proceed. Let us now acquaint ourselves with the process of value education which we are going to adopt. In this course, various aspects of reality facilitating the understanding of human values will be as proposals. You need to verify these proposals for yourself and examine your living in this light. Let us see how we can verify these proposals.

- ☐ We will verify these proposals through self-exploration. We shall investigate into these proposals and try to verify within us in our own right.
- This self-exploration will be done on the basis of whether the proposals are acceptable to us in a natural manner – i.e. they need to be naturally acceptable to us and not just imposed externally.
- ☐ Self-exploration will also include verifying the proposals through experiential validation, i.e. by living according to them. Experiential validation will ascertain that when we live our life on the basis of this education, our living will be fulfilling to us as well as our surroundings.
- Since the process is of self-exploration, and not of giving sermons or prescribing do's and don'ts, you need not agree to all that is said, but only be ready to investigate into them sincerely. We don't want to just theorize and impose stated truths.

- This process of self-exploration has to be in the form of a dialogue, a dialogue between the presenter and the receivers to begin with; and slowly to translate into a dialogue within the receiver himself/herself. Each one of us can conduct this verification within ourselves.

Possible Questions:

- 1.** What is the need for value education in technical and other professional institutions?
- 2.** What do you mean by values? How do they differ from skills? How are values and skills complementary?
- 3.** How do you presently decide what is valuable to you? How do you ensure that your decision is right?
- 4.** What is the difference between ‘belief’ and ‘understanding’?

CHAPTER TWO

Self-Exploration as the Process for Value Education

What is Self-Exploration? What is its purpose?

1. It is a process of dialogue between ‘what you are’ and ‘what you really want to be’.

It is a process of focusing attention on yourself, your present beliefs and aspirations vis-à-vis what you really want to be (that is to say, what is naturally acceptable to you). It is a process of discovering that there is something innate, invariant and universal in all human beings. This enables us to look at our confusions and contradictions within and resolve them by becoming aware of our natural acceptance.

2. It is a process of self-evolution through self-investigation.

It successively enables you to evolve by bridging the above gap- the gap between ‘what you are’ and ‘what you really want to be’.

3. It is a process of knowing oneself and through that knowing entire existence.

The exploration starts by asking simple questions about yourself, which gives you clarity about your being, and then slowly gain clarity about everything around you.

4. It is a process of recognizing one’s relation with every unit in existence and fulfilling it.

It is a process of becoming aware about your relationship with other entities in existence and through that discovering the interconnectedness, co-existence and order in the entire existence, and living accordingly.

5. It is a process of knowing human conduct, human character and living accordingly.

It is a process of discovering the definitiveness of human conduct and human character and enabling one to be definite in thought, behavior and work.

6. It is a process of being in harmony in oneself and in harmony with entire existence.

This process of self-exploration helps you be in harmony within yourself, and in harmony with everything around.

7. It is a process of Swatantrata and Swarajya starting from exploration of Swatva.

Swatva: Innateness of Self – The natural acceptance.

Swatantrata: Self organized: Being in harmony in oneself

Swarajya: Self Expression, Self-Extension - living in harmony with others and thus participation towards harmony in the whole existence.

Swatva → Swatantrata → Swarajya

The Swatva is already there intact in each one of us. Just by being in dialogue with it, we attain Swatantrata enabling us to work for Swarajya.

Content of Self Exploration

1. Desire/Goal? - What is my (human) Desire/Goal
2. Program? - What is my (human) program for fulfilling the Desire

The main focus of self-exploration is myself- the Human Being. Basically, it should dwell on the following two key questions:

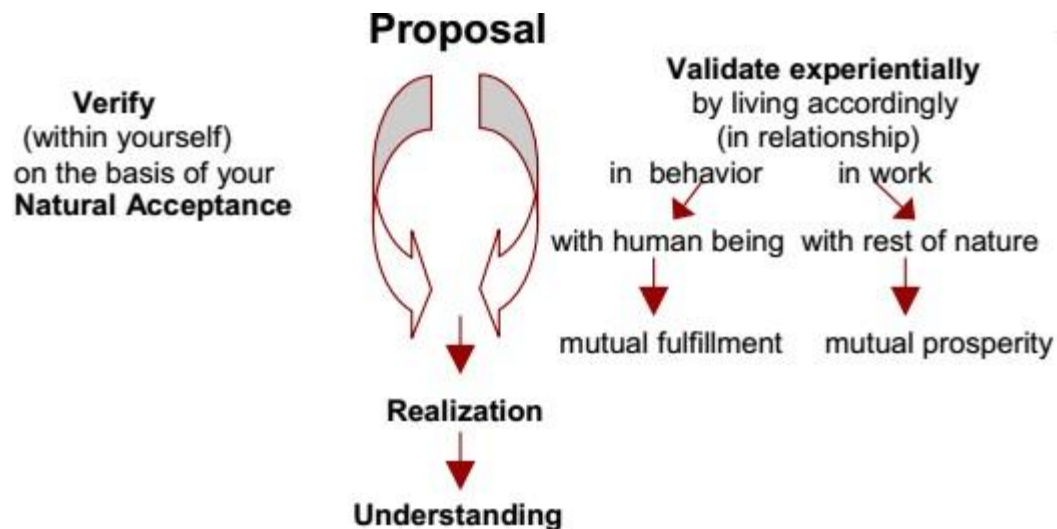
1. What do I really want in life, or what is the goal of human life?
2. How to fulfil it? What is the program to actualize the above?

In short, the above two questions cover the whole domain of human aspirations and human endeavor. Thus, it forms the content of self-exploration.

Process of Self Exploration

whatever is being presented is a PROPOSAL.

- Don't assume it to be true
- Verify at your own right, on the basis of it being naturally acceptable
 - Not on the basis of scriptures
 - Not on the basis of equipment/ instrument
 - Not on the basis of other humans.



Take for example: a proposal- ‘respect’ is a value in human relation. When I verify at the level of natural acceptance, I find that it is naturally acceptable to me. Similarly, when I behave with respect, it is mutually fulfilling to me and to the other. Thus the proposal is true. If it fails on any of the two tests, it is untrue. This verification leads to realization of the truthfulness of the proposal and it becomes part and parcel of my understanding. It is reflected in my thoughts, and in my behavior.

Natural Acceptance

At this point, we can make the following observations about natural acceptance:

- (a) **Natural acceptance does not change with time:** The natural acceptance does not change with time. It remains invariant with time. This can be easily verified. For example, our acceptance for trust or respect does not change with age. People hundred years ago also had the same natural acceptance. We can try to verify this within our span of observation.
- (b) **It does not depend on the place:** Whether we are in New Delhi, New York or Abu Dhabi, if we address our natural acceptance, the answer would still be the same!
- (c) **It does not depend on our beliefs or past conditionings:** We may be told frequently not to trust people of other religions or castes, but is it naturally acceptable to us? No matter how deep our belief or past conditioning, as long as we ask ourselves the question sincerely, as long as we refer deep within ourselves, the answer will always be the same.

(d) **This natural acceptance is ‘constantly there’, something we can refer to:** Try this yourself: think of cheating or exploiting someone. The *moment* you think of this, you sense a contradiction within and feel unhappy that *very instant!* It happens very quickly, and we may not notice it, but it does happen! Similarly, the moment we think of disrespecting someone, we become unhappy. The very thought is enough to cause a conflict, a strain within us. Thus, this natural acceptance is always there, and if we start paying attention to it, if we ask ourselves every time, for every thought and every desire we have, “Is this naturally acceptable to me?”, we will get an answer. Whatever we do, this natural acceptance is within us, it is telling us what is right. Every time we do something not readily acceptable to us, i.e. every time we think or do something not acceptable to us, there is a contradiction in us, because the thought/ deed conflicts with our own natural acceptance! The moment we think of cheating, we become unhappy. We don’t even have to carry out the action. It will become clear to us that while we want something else at the level of our natural acceptance, we think or do something else, based on our beliefs and preconditioning, which is contrary, it creates a disharmony in us; this is the cause for our unhappiness. Take for example, one may proceed with the act of cheating under the influence of say, an extraneous pressure but one keeps feeling unhappy about it and may even repent over this act in the course of time. If somebody asks, ‘why do you cheat?’, one starts offering explanations, inventing justifications. This is because it is naturally unacceptable.

Natural acceptance is the same for all of us: it is part and parcel of every human being, it is part of humanness: Let’s start exploring into this. We will find that no human being finds disrespect acceptable in relationship. No matter who the person, however bad or good, one always expects respect in relationship. For example, let us say a person ‘A’ disrespects ‘B’. This man ‘B’ may bear a grudge against ‘A’ and set out to “teach him a lesson”. This is because ‘B’ does not find disrespect acceptable and when he does not get respect, it offends him. This may actually end up leading to a large scale conflict!

Possible Questions

1. Self-exploration is a process of dialogue between ‘what you are’ and what you really want to be’. Explain.
2. What is the content of Self-exploration?
3. Explain the process of self-exploration with the help of a diagram?
4. What do you mean by your natural acceptance? Illustrate with examples. Is it invariant with time and place?
5. What do you understand by the terms Svatva, Swatantrata and Swarajya?
6. Do you feel that you have some pre-conditionings? How do you evaluate them?

CHAPTER THREE

The Basic Human Aspirations – Continuous Happiness and Prosperity

Make a list of all that you want in your life and reasons for wanting them. For example, when you start listing, your list may comprise of things such as- to be an engineer or an MBA professional, to get the highest grade, to be the first ranker in the examination, to be the smartest guy in the crowd, to be the master of all trades, to earn more wealth than the wealthiest person in the world, etc. Once you have made the list, see if there is anything basic to all of them? Is there any basic aspiration of yours behind all your wants? This is an exercise worth doing to find out your basic aspiration?

Let us say, you want to be the first ranker in the class. Now, behind this desire to get the first rank, is there a more basic desire? Why do you want to get the first rank? If you keep asking this question, you will find that there is a basic desire. What is this desire, is it to be happy? Yes, it is!

Desire – Continuous Happiness and Prosperity

Verify whether you want to be happy or unhappy.

Verify whether you want to be prosperous or deprived.

List all your desires. See whether the basic aspiration in that desire is happiness and/or prosperity.

Verify whether you want continuity of happiness and prosperity or discontinuity of happiness and prosperity?

Exploring Happiness and Prosperity

Happiness: the state / situation, in which I live, if there is harmony/synergy in it, then I like to be in that state or situation. To be in a state of liking is happiness. To be in harmony is Happiness.

Unhappiness: -If there is contradiction /disharmony in it, then I don't like to be in that state. To be forced to be in that state of disliking is unhappiness.

Prosperity-

Prosperity: is the feeling of having or making available more than required physical facilities.

To ascertain prosperity, two things are essential:

- (a) Correct assessment of need for physical facilities, and
- (b) The competence of making available more than required physical facilities (through production).

One needs to ask oneself- Is prosperity abundance of physical facilities? Is it having more and more of certain kinds of physical facilities? Or, is it a correct appraisal of my physical needs and ensuring more than what I need in terms of physical facilities?

Difference between Wealth and Prosperity

Wealth is a physical thing. It means having money, or having a lot of physical facilities, or both.

Prosperity is a feeling of having more than required. Prosperity is a feeling of having more than required physical facilities; it is not just physical facilities.

A look at the Prevailing Notions of Happiness and Prosperity and their consequences

In the light of the above discussion, let us have a critical look at the prevailing notions of happiness and prosperity. In the current scenario, we are generally trying to achieve happiness and prosperity by maximizing accumulation and consumption of physical facilities. This is an attempt to achieve happiness through pleasant sensory interactions. The physical facilities are not seen in terms of fulfilling bodily needs but as a means of maximizing happiness. This has resulted in wrong assessment of wants for physical facilities as being unlimited. But this pursuit is self-defeating. Neither can we hope to achieve continuous happiness through sensory interactions nor can we have prosperity, as it amounts to trying to fulfil unlimited wants through limited resources. This effort is engendering problems at all the levels. It is becoming anti-ecological and anti-people, and threatening the human survival itself. Some of the consequences of such a trend are summarized below:

At the level of the individual – rising problems of depression, psychological disorders, suicides, stress, insecurity, psychosomatic diseases, loneliness etc.

At the level of the family – breaking of joint families, mistrust, conflict between older and younger generations, insecurity in relationships, divorce, dowry tortures, family feuds, wasteful expenditure in family functions etc.

At the level of the Society – growing incidences of terrorism and naxalism, rising communalism, spreading casteism, racial and ethnic struggle, wars between nations, attempts of genocide, fear of nuclear and genetic warfare, etc.

At the level of nature – global warming, water, air, soil, noise, etc. pollution, resource depletion of minerals and mineral oils, sizeable deforestations, loss of fertility of soil.

Possible misconceptions about happiness

- ☐ I will be bored of happiness if I am always happy.
- ☐ I will grow only if I am unhappy. If I become happy, my growth will stop.
- ☐ I need to be unhappy to recognize that I am happy.
- ☐ We think of others only when we are unhappy. Thus it is important/useful to be unhappy so that one can help others.
- ☐ Happiness and unhappiness go together, they cannot be separated.
- ☐ Yes, I want happiness. But my desiring does not guarantee it. So, why to talk of desire?
- ☐ My happiness depends on the others. What can I do about it?
- We do not want happiness for ourselves – but we want to make others happy (while we stay unhappy).

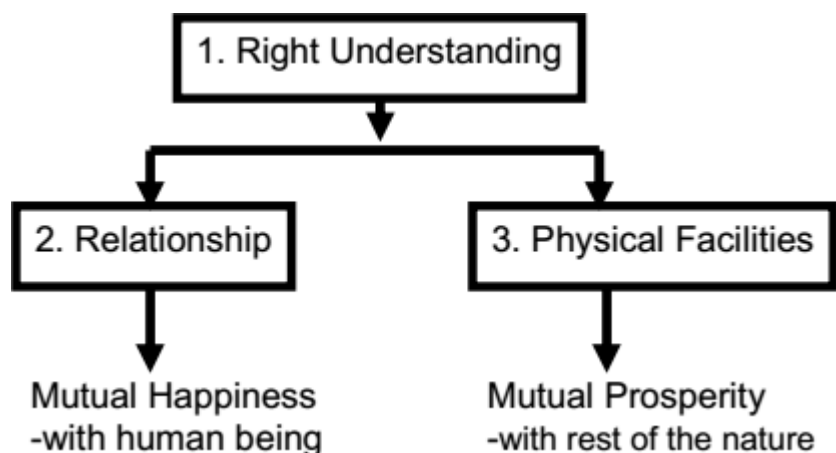
Possible Questions

1. “To be in state of harmony is happiness.” Examine this statement and illustrate with two examples from your day-to-day life.
2. What do you understand by prosperity? What is the difference between prosperity and wealth? How are the two related?
3. What is your present vision of a happy and prosperous life?
4. Critically examine the prevailing notions of happiness and prosperity and their consequences.
5. “I will learn and improve only if I am unhappy. If I become happy, my learning will stop”. Explore the validity of this viewpoint.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Program to Fulfil Basic Human Aspirations

The basic requirements for fulfilment of aspirations of every human being:



- ☐ One requirement for fulfilment of aspiration of every human being is **physical facilities** which includes food, clothing, shelter and implements etc. Is this all that we want? Or we want something more than this? Can we find what else do we want?
- ☐ Other than physical facilities, I want **relationship**. I live with other human beings and relationship is an important issue here.
- If I look at the miseries in my life – what do I find? Are the miseries mostly due to lack of physical facilities or lack of relationship? This I need to explore in my family situation first.
- ☐ Where am I putting in most of my efforts? In earning of physical facilities or in ensuring relationship. This is a common fallacy in our lives that a large part of our problems are due to lack of relationships though most of the time, effort and attention is focused on earning physical facilities.
- ☐ Thus there are 3 requirements - Right Understanding, Relationship and Physical Facilities.

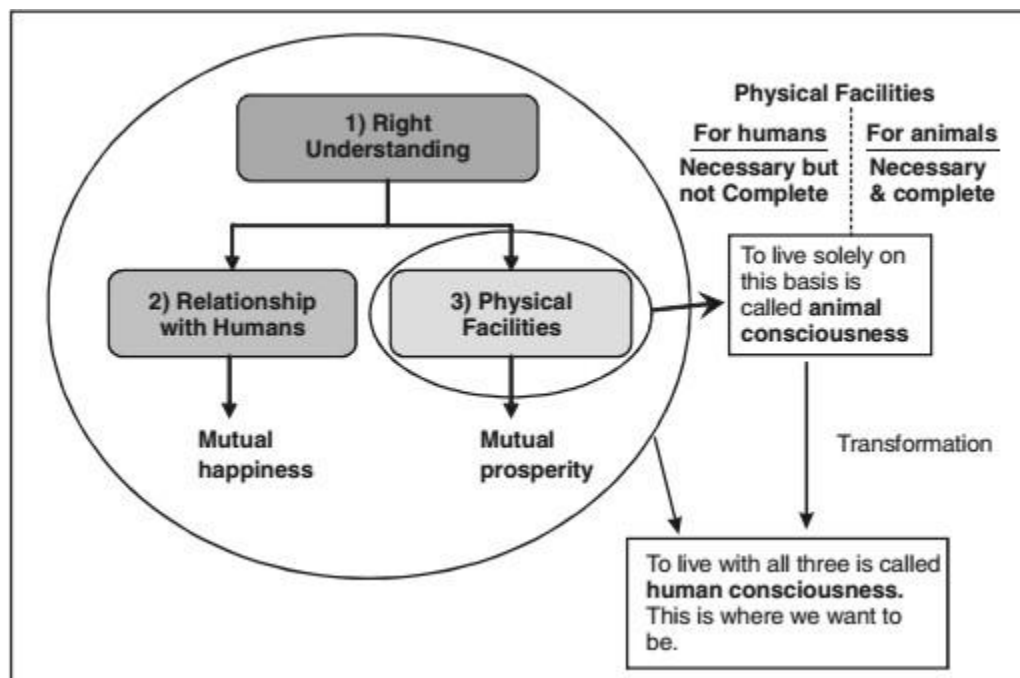
The correct priority:

1. Right Understanding
2. Relationship
3. Physical Facilities

What is the order amongst these? If I work for Right Understanding then I am able to ensure right Feelings in my relationship and assess my need of physical facilities correctly. Right Understanding, thus, is the first priority. The second priority is Relationship. Working with Right Understanding and right feelings in relationship – the need for physical facilities can be easily accessed and fulfilled. Thus Physical Facilities is the third priority. And, of course, we need all the three.

- For animal physical facility is necessary as well as complete– whereas for human beings it is necessary but not complete.
- Working only for physical facilities is living with **Animal Consciousness**
- Working for right understanding as the first priority followed by relationship and then physical facilities is living with **Human Consciousness**.

There is need for transformation from Animal Consciousness to Human Consciousness. It can be accomplished only by working for right understanding as the first priority.



Presently, as we look around, we find most of the people in the following two categories:
SVDD – Sadhan Viheen Dukhi Daridra

SSDD – Sadhan Sampann Dukhi Daridra

While the natural acceptance of all human beings is to be

SSSS- Sadhan Sampann Sukhi Samriddha

Let us explore the above suggestion. Is it true?

- One can assess, in which of these three categories one lies, SVDD, SSDD or SSSS?
- If we are working only for physical facilities, the maximum achievement that one could have is that one could shift from SVDD to SSDD. But the goal is to be SSSS. And this can be accomplished only by working for right understanding and relationship.

What is the prevailing notion about happiness and its continuity?

Explore and analyze what is the present perception about happiness and its continuity. Indicate how fulfilling the present perception has proven to be.

- A common notion among people is that continuous happiness can be achieved through maximization of pleasant sensory interactions.
- Explore the truthfulness of the above by verifying at the level of your natural acceptance. Also, investigate it by studying the consequences of such a notion in the present scenario. Is it possible to ensure continuity of happiness through sensory interactions, through maximization of pleasant interactions? Is it not self-defeating? Analyze, discuss some case studies.

What is the prevailing notion about attaining prosperity?

- Analyze what is the prevailing notion about prosperity--maximization of physical facilities? - struggling to meet unlimited wants with limited resources?
- In such a situation, is it ever possible to be prosperous? Is it possible to maintain harmony with Nature, to maintain ecological balance in this way?
- And if the above balance is increasingly disturbed, can human survival be at all sustained on this planet? Again, with unlimited wants and limited resources, exploitation and strife among human beings becomes inevitable. In such a situation, are peaceful and harmonious co-existence of human beings ever possible?

Possible Questions

1. What are the basic requirements to fulfill human aspirations? Indicate their correct priority.
2. “Physical facilities are necessary and complete for animals, while they are necessary but not complete for humans.” Comment.
3. Critically examine our state today in terms of fulfillment of relationships and physical facilities. What has gone wrong according to you? What is the solution?
4. What do the abbreviations given as SVDD, SSDD and SSSS signify? Explain the reason for the state SSDD?
5. “Right understanding + Relationship = Mutual fulfillment;
Right understanding + Physical facilities = Mutual prosperity” Illustrate the above with two examples for each.
6. What is the program to fulfill the basic human aspirations? Name the different levels of human living?
7. What is the difference between ‘animal consciousness’ and ‘human consciousness’? Explain with the help of a diagram.

Reference:

1. **A foundation Course in Human Values and Professional Ethics by R.R. Gaur, R. Sangal, G P Bagaria. Excel Books Private Limited, 2015.**